Pakistan. Firstly, the money. Cricket is more commercialized than ever before. It's played for the wrong reasons by many.

Secondly, stars aren't groomed properly. There's an aggressive revolving door. New talent emerges and is routed out and dusted off as quickly if it doesn't perform. It's all a business now. You play for money and you're treated like a commodity.

Building a good national team is like building a family. It's simple, really. Once your system is sorted at the grass-roots, where a U-14 or U-16 player is getting all that he needs to excel, then you've naturally taken care of talent required at the highest level – the national level. You can't hope to have a line-up of healthy, strong sons if you don't feed them as babies. So India's secret – and it's not really a secret – is that it has taken care of the bottom of the system, and therefore it can look after its young and upcoming stars.

As for Pakistan, if we are interested in consistency, we will need to replicate and even improve upon the Indian system. Currently, we are in this permanent back and forth, in and out of good runs and bad patches. A good series here, a terrible whitewash there, two bad years in Tests, one good year in ODIs, a trophy and then a scandal, and round and round we go. People call it Pakistani flair; I call it consistent inconsistency.

We must ask ourselves – do we want Pakistan cricket to be the way it is, without a stable growth trajectory, always through ups and downs, or do we want to excel consistently? If nothing else, even if we plan on playing regularly against India, if not for the sake of our rivalry but for the country and ourselves, we will have to create a new system of cricket.

Having said that, I'm not the sort of guy who only blames 'the system' or 'the machine'. It's time for some other admissions.

Our cricketers have issues. We all do. I will be the first one to admit mine. The biggest problem is related to our ambition. Once he makes it to the national squad, the typical Pakistani cricketer wants to play on forever. Only the might of the selection committee and/or political intervention can dethrone him. Given a choice, a national-level cricketer would play on till he was 50 years old if he felt like it. He wants to hold on to his place in the team at all costs.

This is pure selfishness. Our players don't want anyone else to rise and replace them. Thus, there is no co-practising, nor any mentoring or grooming or tutoring where, say, an old star like Sachin Tendulkar will help mentor a rising star like Virat Kohli. The Indians have this approach. We don't.

Everybody has a natural tendency for self-preservation. But I'm not talking about survival instincts here. I'm talking about the habit to worry more for ourselves and less for the team and the future of the game. This is a shortsighted approach based on immediacy and is used by those who can't see beyond the short run. There is no big-picture approach to the game, something for the long haul where cricket can actually grow. It's all about 'me, here and now'. It's not about others, the next generation and how the game must change. It's about today, not tomorrow.

That's not how you play the game. That's not how you live.

This mentality is our collective problem. I'm a part of it for sure. But it's also a problem of the PCB. The PCB should be proactive about figuring out the next steps for these great, talented cricketers who have given their best years to the country and are now past their prime. They all need a graceful retirement plan that protects both the game and the player.

If the PCB could call a once-great player, sit across the table from him, pay some attention